

USUCGER Annual Meeting 2018 Minutes
Sunday, May 20, 2018, 1:30-3:30pm EDT

1. President's report (Olson)

Scott Olson called the meeting to order at 1:45 pm EDT.

Roll Call:

Partial list - In attendance (In person and online):

Scott Olson

Ed Kavazanjian

Ben Leshchinsky

Cassie Rutherford

Shideh Dashti

Ellen Rathje

Hyoueng Seo

Angel Palomino

Gretchen Bohnhoff

Rick Fragazy

Seung Jae Lee

Junxing Zheng

Thomas Zimmie

a. Overview of Early Career Workshop

Located Case Western Reserve University - Two day workshop for early career geotechnical engineering faculty Monday May 21-22, 2018

b. Two new special projects

Dr. Cheng Zhu, Rowan University, "Creation of a library of novel examples for an enriching geotechnical engineering learning experiences"

Drs. Junxing Zheng and Vern Schaefer Iowa State University, "Development of an Augmented Reality Sandbox to Teach Spatial-Visualization"

c. Other

Two new board members: Dr. Gretchen Bohnhoff and Dr. Kyle Rollins

2. Treasurer's report (Qiu given by Olson)

a. Account balance

Current bank balance: \$26,113.18 (as of 5/17/18)

PayPal balance: \$24,817.62 (as of 5/17/18)

Part of combined balance (~\$20,000) is committed and will be used for Early Career Workshop and new Small Grants

b. Membership Renewals

Switched to 3 year membership cycle

Dues drive began in Dec. 2016

Still in progress, currently about 85% complete

Sent individual emails to those who have not yet renewed.

ACTION: Ben - Send email to membership to update university representative

ACTION: Ben - Send email to individuals who have not paid and copy other local faculty

ACTION: Board to discuss confirmation of membership emails

ACTION: Ben – Send email to membership with list of currently activate membership

3. Webmaster's report (Leshchinsky)

a. Membership renewals (continued)

Due drive (2016-2018) still ongoing

New membership drive starts in 7 months

Long term growth of USUCGER is positive. 80 new members this drive.

current total 454 members, 34 associate members, total 137 universities

b. Report on website renovation

Updated website, now mostly maintenance

Helped coordinate election through the web with Dashti.

Google analytics page created. Over 400 monthly visitors primarily from US, with 250 new monthly visitors. Over 660 session per month. Academic positions page most visited

4. 2018 elections (for 2019 – 2023 board members) (Dashti)

a. Terms ending for Rathje and Olson – extend term for Olson?

Dashti compiled the chart below. Olson doesn't need to be extended at this time (2015-2019). Board terms end for Tanya Kunberger and Shidei Dashti (2014-2018) and Tong Qiu (2012-2018).

President	Scott Olson	University of Illinois Urbana Champaign	2015-2019
Secretary	Tong Qiu	Pennsylvania State University	2012-2018
Comptroller	Tanya Kunberger	Florida Gulf Coast University	2014-2018
	Shideh Dashti	University of Colorado Boulder	2014-2018
	Scott Olson	University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign	2015-2019
	Ellen Rathje	University of Texas-Austin	2015-2019
	Cassandra Rutherford	Iowa State University	2017-2021
	Christopher Swan	Tufts University	2017-2021
Past-President	Edward Kavazangian	Arizona State University	ex-officio
Treasurer	Christopher Meehan	University of Delaware	ex-officio
Treasurer	Tong Qiu	Pennsylvania State University	2016-
Webmaster	Ben Leshchinsky	Oregon State University	2016-

ACTION: Shideh to update Tong (ex-officio member) and Cassie (secretary) on chart

b. Timeline and procedures for 2018 elections

Nominating ad hoc subcommittee for elections: volunteers from the board (Dashti, Rathje, Leshchinsky).

ACTION: Dashti, Rathje, and Leshchinsky will identify 2-3 additional USUCGER members to join ad hoc elections subcommittee

c. Review of and updates to By-Laws

The votes will be tallied and the new Board members will be notified at least six weeks in advance of the first Board meeting of the next calendar year so as to make proper arrangements to attend, if the meeting is not by teleconference. The meeting is typically held in the first quarter of the year.

Nominations shall be announced to the members by September 30th and additional nominations shall be solicited. The nominations will close on October 30th and the elections will be held. The Executive Secretary will then ask the member institution delegates to cast their votes on the nominees by December 1st.

Board members serve on Ad hoc committees as need. Elections ad hoc committee will solicit new board member nominations via email to the membership and also will make their own nominations. After all nominations have been received, ad hoc elections committee will propose slate of nominees to the Board for approval. After approval, the slate of nominees will be announced to the membership.

5. Report on USUCGER special project, “Soil Magic 2.0: Creation of a library of group activities...” (Seo)

- a. Dr. Hoyoung Seo, Texas Tech University “*Soil Magic 2.0: Creation of a library of in-class demonstration activities to create ‘aha moments’ in geotechnical engineering classrooms*”

9/1/2017-8/31/2018 Budget: \$5000

The proposed project aims to develop a library of demonstration activities to present various concepts and principles in geotechnical engineering in a more tangible way. Although a few resources (such as Dr. Elton’s two books, *Soil Magic* and *Grounded*) are available for the activities that can be done in a lab-style classroom, this project focuses on developing instructional materials facilitating demonstration activities in a lecture-style classroom.

Deliverables:

- Learning modules for each activity: The learning modules will consist of a) Learning Objective, b) Introduction, c) Materials needed for activity, d) Activity setup procedure, e) Operation of the activity, f) Aha moment, and g) Further discussion.
- Whiteboard-style animations including video recordings of each activity: Posted on Youtube (channel: I Love Geotech)
- Example Activity A-3 The magic wand was demonstrated

A list of additional activities is listed below:

Activity name	Activity objective
A1. A sliding cup	To demonstrate the behavior of dry cohesionless soil slope using a 3-ring binder and a water cup
A2. Playdough revival	To demonstrate clay-water interaction by reviving dried-out playdough
A3. A magic wand	To demonstrate the shaft resistance of deep foundations by lifting up a cylindrical container filled with sand using a wooden stick
A4. Terzaghi bearing capacity	To illustrate the concepts of bearing pressure and bearing capacity and to visualize Terzaghi's bearing capacity failure mechanism
A5. A sweet tube	To demonstrate the interlocking behavior and sampling process of granular soil by taking a sample of sugar grain using a straw
A5. Reinforced soil	To demonstrate the concept of reinforced soil using a sand and a coffee filter
A6. Liquid soil	To visualize soil liquefaction using a small cup, silty sand and water, and to relate the behavior with effective stress concept.
A7. Water race	To assess the hydraulic conductivity of various soils by pouring water into gravel, sand, silt, and clay by observing how fast water is coming out of the soil.
A8. Poor chopstick	To demonstrate the concept of long pile vs. short pile in lateral pile behavior by observing how laterally loaded chopsticks in the soil behave differently depending on embedment depth.

ACTION: Hoyoung Seo will send video links to Ben

- b. Dr. Kurt Sjoblom, Drexel University, he was unable to complete the project and will be returning the money.

6. Other business

- a. Updates on mentoring initiative (Rutherford; 2:25pm, 10 mins)

Survey to membership for topics for “TED” style webinars.

Encourage membership to seek online and local resources for example: National Center for Faculty Development and Diversity for webinars on time management, semester plans, daily writing, networking, saying No and overcoming academic perfectionism. For teaching resources, local school instruction centers and ASCE ExCEED programs.

Scott and Cassie are working with Lucky Nagargian from Women in Deep Foundations for industry partnerships and outreach opportunities

Discussion:

- Ed recommended non-academic mentoring through GeoCoalition
- Amy – during early career was matched with 3 senior faculty for CV review prior to tenure. Recommended a matching program.
- Shoba – mentoring and networking information from NSF project will be posted online

b. Women in GeoEngineering (Bhatia 2:35 15 mins)

Presentation by Shoba Bhatia on NSF project funded 2 years ago. The focus was to create a network for collaboration and mentoring for women and men in geotechnical engineering. Social science was used to study networks. 2 workshops were organized. Surveys of 80 faculty were completed. 20 small grants (\$5000) for collaborations were granted. Mini grants were very successful and showed in person meetings best for effective collaborations. Information and data will be posted to GeoWorld.

c. USUCGER initiatives (All; 2:50pm, 15 mins)

1. Expanded mentoring program. Specifically, I would like to see the USUCGER website contain a discussion board where members can post questions, and a board member is responsible for responding or soliciting responses. (This could be a rotating thing or left open for anyone to respond, but I was thinking more like an ask-an-expert forum.) This would have another beneficial effect of driving traffic to the website and highlight other resources available on the website. (Can we use USUCGER funds to hire a web programmer to do this?)

Discussion

- Have faculty sign up as mentors and find mentors
- Ellen – seed some questions and answers and have board members responsible for answering
- Ed – Geosynthetics has an ask an expert but didn't work out.
- Scott – questions would be focused on mentoring and tenure/promotion, not consulting
- Ben – set a specific time for questions
- Board members could set up a time to be available online
- Use money returned from special project for web programmer
- Ellen – slack on designsafe and other online forums available

ACTION: Ellen can have her people work with Ben to figure out a system

2. Letter-writing campaign. As you are almost certainly aware, the recent changes at NSF mean that there are no dedicated geotechnical programs. These changes could have a significantly negative impact on geotechnical research, particularly on early career academics trying to establish independent research programs and earn tenure. I propose that we initiate a letter-writing campaign to the NSF director, program directors, and others at NSF to express our concern regarding these changes. I would like first to recruit NAE members to sign on to a letter that we prepare, then send another letter from all of USUCGER (getting members to sign on), and follow-up these letters with postcards that highlight key research funded by NSF and other programs, particularly focusing on how this research has impacted practice. Ben, can we do this electronically?

Discussion

- Ed – should we send individual letters vs one letter signed by a large number for faculty
 - Rick – timing might be best when new CMMI division director is appointed
3. Develop a white paper that summaries the highlights from the Early Career Workshop and updates the "Do's and don'ts list for promotion and tenure.

Discussion

- Plan Web/live stream workshop
- ask workshop organizers to update Promotion and Tenure document online
- Cassie – update the “how to get funding”
- Cassie – is it possible to record sessions to upload to website?

ACTION: Scott will talk with Bill regarding livestreaming and links to recorded sessions.

4. Practitioner survey. Conduct a survey of practitioners (either broad or selective) to ask what practitioners want/need from academics; what's good and bad about journal publications; how they would like to work with faculty; what opportunities are there for early career faculty to work with practitioners; are there practitioners interested in mentoring early career faculty; among other topics.

Discussion

- Muesser Rutledge as possible partner
 - GBA – geotechnical business association will be encouraged to be involved at next GeoCongress
 - Ed – this has been an issue for many years. GeoCoalition may be best way forward
5. USUCGER electronic newsletter. This would highlight new additions to the website, updates from researchers who have USUCGER special projects, progress on our initiatives, among other items. Monthly or quarterly.

d. Discussion (All; 3:00pm, 30 mins)

1. Post doc primary visit website for faculty listings
2. Who can be representatives of an institution for USUCGER?
 - Institutional memberships are for each university representing all faculty at each school
 - Post-docs can be associate members
 - What are the different membership levels?
 - PhD students and MS can join under the sponsorship of their major advisor - This needs to be checked by the board.

3. List of open faculty positions – we need to verify that postings are up-to-date
 - Members and Board members can email webmaster to update
 - Recommended with posting date and then automatically removing after set date
 - Individual faculty send faculty posting to website
4. Ellen – Encourage newsletter idea,
 - Cassie – Celebrations section
 - Quarterly newsletter
 - Needs content
5. Ben – can members send email if having issues?
 - Can we hire someone to help Ben to automate the website?
 - Ed – Matt could hire someone to help? For \$500-1000 for student.

ACTION: Ben – will get some numbers together for help to automate website.

ACTION: If workshop is live broadcast, Scott will send with links this evening.

7. Adjourn at 3:29 pm EDT

Summary of Action items:

ACTION: Ben - Send email to membership to update university representative

ACTION: Ben - Send email to individual who have not paid and copy other local faculty

ACTION: Ben – Send email to membership with list of currently activate membership

ACTION: Shideh to update Tong (ex-officio member) and Cassie (secretary) on chart

ACTION: Shideh, Ellen and Ben will come up a list for remaining nomination committee

ACTION: Hoyoung Seo will send video links to Ben

ACTION: Ellen can have her people work with Ben to figure out a system

ACTION: Scott will talk with Bill regarding recording workshop sessions.

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